Supremi Apostolatus Officio

Leo XIII · 1883-09-01 · English

Encyclical Letter of our Most Holy Lord, Leo XIII., by Divine Providence Pope.

To ALL THE PATBIABCHS, PbIMATES, AbCHBISHOPS AND BlSHOPS op the Catholic Wobld in the Gbace and Communion of the Apostolic See.

Venebable Bbethren, Health and Apostolic Benediction : We are daily admonished, and almost compelled by the supreme apostolic office which we hold, and by the great difficulties of these times, to consult most carefully for the protection and integrity of the Church, inasmuch as the calamities which fall upon her are becoming greater. While, therefore, we endeavour, as far as lies in our power, to defend in every way the rights of the Church, to repel actual, and to guard against impending dangers, we implore unceasingly the aid of heaven, by which alone our cares and labours can have the desired effect. We believe that nothing conduces to this end more surely or more efficaciously than to merit, by acts of religion and piety, the favour of the great Virgin Mary, the Mother of God, who is the mediatrix of our peace with God, and the administratrix of heavenly favours ; who is placed on the highest summit of power and glory in heaven, that she may bestow the aid of her patronage on men who are endeavouring, through so many labours and dangers, to reach that eternal city. Hence, as the anniversary approaches, in which we recall to mind the many and exceedingly great favours conferred on a Christian people by the devotion of the Rosary, it is our desire that this year the whole Catholic world should, with the greatest fervour, make use of that same devotion to the great Virgin, in order that, through her intercession, we may have the happiness to find her Divine Son appeased and softened by our misfortunes. We have, therefore, determined, Venerable Brethren, to address this letter to you, in order that, knowing our desires, you may, by your zeal and authority, excite the piety of the people to fulfil them.

It has ever been the custom of Catholics, in times of anxiety and danger, to fly to Mary and seek repose in her maternal kindness; and this custom is evidence not alone of the hope, but of that firmest confidence which the Catholic Church has always and justly placed in the Mother of God. And truly the Immaculate Virgin, chosen to be God's Mother, and thereby associated with Him in the salvation of the human race, has such power and favour with her Son that no creature, human or angelic, has ever obtained, or ever can obtain greater. And since it is agreeable and greatly pleasing to her to help and comfort all who solicit her assistance, it cannot be doubted that she is most willing, and almost passionately anxious, to grant the petitions of the universal Church.

This devotion, so great and so full of trust, to the august Queen of Heaven, has always shone forth with greater brilliancy whenever the violence of wide-spread heresies, or a deluge of moral corruption, or the attacks of powerful enemies, seemed to endanger the militant Church of God.

The histories of ancient and modern times, and the more sacred annals of the Church, recount the public and private supplications and petitions addressed to the Mother of God, and the help which in return was granted, and the peace and tranquillity which through her intercession was obtained from God. Hence those illustrious titles with which Catholic nations have sainted her — Helper of Christians, Bringer of Aid, Consoler, Powerful in War, Conqueror, Giver of Peace. And amongst them is to be specially commemorated the familiar title, derived from the Rosary, by which the signal blessings she obtained for the whole Christian world have been solemnly perpetuated. There is none among you, Venerable Brethren, who is ignorant of the great trouble and affliction brought, towards the close of the 12th century, on the holy Church of God by the • Albigensian heretics, who. springing from the sect of later Manic^eans, filled the south of France and other portions of the Latin world with their pernicious errors, and carrying eveiywhere the terror of their arms, endeavoured to rule far and wide by bloodshed and devastation. Against these fearful enemies the God of Mercy, as you are aware, raised up a most holy man, namely, the illustrious parent and founder of the Dominican Order Great in his integrity of doctrine, in his practice of virtue, in the discharge of his apostolic duty, he undertook with lofty courage to do battle for the Catholic Church, not by force of arms, but by relying entirely on that devotion which, under the name of the Holy Rosary, he was the first to institute, and which was spread far and wide by him and his disciples. By a divine instinct and inspiration he felt convinced that this devotion, like a most powerful instrument of war, would be the means of defeating and completely subduing the enemy, and of compelling them to lay aside their insane presumption and impiety. And this was, indeed, the result For when that method of prayer was adopted, and properly performed according to the institution of the holy Father Dominic, piety, faith, and union began to return, whilst the projects and artifices of the heretics were completely frustrated. Moreover, many who had gone astray were brought back to the way of salvation, and the frenzy of the wicked was checked by

the Catholic arms which had been taken up to repel violence.

The efficacy and power of this same devotion was also made manifest in a wonderful way during the 16th century, when the vast forces of the Turks endeavoured to impose on nearly the whole of Europe the yoke of superstition and barbarism. At that time the Sovereign Pontiff, St. Pius V., aroused Christian princes to the defence of their common interests, and strove, first of all by the devotion of the Rosary, to obtain for Christendom the assist- ance of the most powerful Mother of God. The grand spectacle which was then beheld by earth and heaven arrested the attention of all. While the faithful soldiers of Christ, ready to shed their blood and lay down their lives in defence of faith and fatherland, fearlessly awaited the enemy near the Gulf of Corinth, the pious band of supplicants who were unable to take part in the struggle, called on Mary for assistance, with one accord saluted her again and again in the words of the Rosary, that she might assist the combatants to victory. Our Lady, moved by the entreaties, granted the aid required ; for in the naval battle fought near the Echinades Islands, the Christian fleet, without much loss, scattered and vanquished the enemy, and gained a magnificent victory. Hence the same Most Holy Pontiff, in order to preserve the memory of so great a blessing, desire that the anniversary of this great struggle should be a feast-day in honour of Our Lady of Victories, and Gregory XIII. dedicated this feast under the title of the Rosary.

In like manner, during the last century, an important victory was gained over the Turks at Temesvar, in Pannonie, and another at the Island of Corfu, both on feasts of the Blessed Virgin, and after the public performance of the pious devotion of the Rosary. And this led Our Predecessor, Clement XI., to decree, as a token of gratitude, that the solemnity of Our Lady of the Rosary should be honoured every year by the entire Church.

Since, therefore, it is evident that this form of prayer is greatly pleasing to the Blessed Virgin, and contributes very much to the defence of the Church and of all Christians, and is, moreover, a suitable means for obtaining publicly and privately Divine blessings, it is not to be wondered at that several others of Our Predecessors have endeavoured, by the highest recommendations, to exalt and extend it. Thus, Urban IV. testified that " every day blessings were conferred on Christians by means of the Rosary Sixtus IV. declared that this form of prayer u contributes to the honour of God and the Blessed Virgin, and averts from the world impending dangers;" Leo X., that "it was instituted against heresiarchs and the increase of heresies;" and Julius III. called it " the glory of the Roman Church." So also St. Pius V. says of it that "with the spread of this devotion the faithful began to be enlightened by its meditations, inflamed by its prayers, and changed suddenly into new men; the darkness of heresy was dispelled, and the light of Catholic faith revealed." Finally, Gregory XIII. declared that 14 the Rosary was instituted by St. Dominic to appease the anger of God, and to implore the intercession of the Blessed Virgin."

Moved by this consideration, and by the examples of Our Pre- decessors, We deem it most advantageous at the present time to institute solemn prayers for the same purpose, so that by the invo- cation of the august Virgin in the recital of the Rosary, we may obtain from her Son, Jesus Christ, similar assistance in our necessities. You have before your eyes, Venerable Brethren, the trials of the Church, her long and severe struggles. We see Christian piety, public morality, and faith itself, which is our chief treasure and the source of the other virtues, daily exposed to the greatest dangers. Our own difficulties and many troubles you are not only aware of, but in your love for us you feel and share them with us. But the most afflicting and by far the most mournful fact is this, that so many souls redeemed by the blood of Jesus Christ, caught as it were by the whirlwind of an erring age, driven from bad to worse, are rushing headlong to everlasting destruction. The need, therefore, of Divine assistance is not less to-day than when the great Dominic introduced the use of Mary's Rosary to heal the wounds of society. Divinely enlightened, he perceived that no remedy could be more efficacious against the evils of his time than that men should return to Christ, who is u the way* the truth, and the life," by frequently meditating on the salvation ob- tained by Him for us ; and that they should beg of the Virgin, to whom it is given " to destroy all heresies," to intercede for them with God. Hence he composed the Rosary in such a way as to recall in order the mysteries of our salvation, and into the medita- tion on the mysteries a mystical wreath is woven out of the Angelical Salutation, with the insertion of the prayer to God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ. We, therefore, who seek a remedy for a similar evil, do not doubt that the same devotion introduced by that most holy man with so much advantage to the Catholic world, will have the greatest influence in removing the calamities of our times also.

Wherefore We not only earnestly exhort all Christians to perform publicly or privately, each in his own home and family, this pious devotion of the Rosary, and that unceasingly, but We also desire that the entire month of October this year be dedicated and consecrated to the heavenly Queen of the Rosary.

W e decree, therefore, and order that this year throughout the whole Catholic world the solemnity of Our lady of the Rosary shall be celebrated with special reverence and ritual splendour, and that from the first day of next October to the second of the follow- ing November, at least five decades of the Rosary, with the

Litany of Loretto, shall be piously recited in all public churches, and, if the Ordinary deem it useful and opportune, in other churches also, and in oratories dedicated to the Mother of God. We desire that when the people attend these devotions, either Mass shall be said at the Altar, or the Blessed Sacrament shall be exposed to the adoration of the faithful, Benediction being afterwards given with the Sacred Host to the pious congregation.

We highly approve of Sodalities of the Blessed Virgin, in accordance with ancient custom, going in procession through the towns from street to street, with solemn pomp, as a demonstration of public devotion. But in those places where such a thing is not permitted by the unjust rigour of the times, let compensation be made for the loss inflicted thereby on public devotion by more numerous visits to the churches ; and let the fervour of piety display itself in the more diligent practice of the Christian virtues.

In favour of those who shall do as We have ordered above, We are pleased to open the heavenly treasures of the Church, that they may find therein, at the same time, incentives and rewards to piety. We grant, therefore, to all who, within the appointed space of time, shall have assisted at the public recital of the Rosary and Litany, and shall have prayed according to Our intentions, an indulgence of seven years and seven quarantines, obtainable each time. We will that they also shall enjoy the same favours who are prevented by a lawful cause from assisting at these public prayers, provided that they shall have practised the same sacred devotion in private, and shall have prayed to God according to Our intention. We remit all punishment and penalties for sins committed, in the form of a Pontifical Indulgence, to all who, within the prescribed time, either publicly in the churches, or privately at home (when hindered by just causes from attending the churches), shall have performed the same devotions at least ten times, and after a proper Confession, shall have approached the Holy Table. We also grant a plenary indulgence to all who, either on the Feast of the Blessed Virgin Mary of the Rosary or within its Octave, after having similarly purified their souls by a salutary confession, shall have approached the Table of Christ, and prayed in some church to God and His Virgin Mother^ according to Our intention, for the necessities of the Church.

And you, Venerable Brethren, the more you care for Mary's honour and the welfare of human society, endeavour the mm diligently to foster the piety of the people towards the great Virgin, and to increase their confidence in her. We believe it due to the Divine Giver of good gifts that in those times of trouble for the Church, the ancient reverence and devotion towards the august Virgin should still exist and flourish among the great majority of Christians. May the nations of Christendom, aroused by these Our exhortations, and inflamed by your words, betake themselves with ever-increasing ardour to the protection and guardian care of Mary ; let them persevere more and more in loving the practice of the Rosary, which our ancestors esteemed not only as an efficacious remedy in misfortunes, but also as the grand token of Christian piety. The heavenly Patroness of the human race will receive with pleasure our united prayers and supplications ; she will obtain for the good an increase of virtue, for the erring repentance and a resolve to secure salvation ; and she will move God, the avenger of crime, to use clemency and mercy, to remove dangers, and restore to Christendom and civil society the peace so much desired.

Encouraged by this hope, We fervently beseech God Himself, with the most earnest desires of Our heart, through her in whom the fulness of all good is placed, to grant you, Venerable Brethren; His choicest heavenly blessings. As an augury and pledge of which We lovingly impart to you, to your clergy, and to the people confided to your care, the Apostolic Benediction.

Given at St. Peter's, Rome, the 1st of September, 18S8, in the sixth year of O ur Pontificate.
LEO PP. XIH.

[We think it better to print this Encyclical Letter in English, as it may furnish to priests useful matter for one or two instructions during the month of October.—Ed.]

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